FLOMASTER

USER GUIDE

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GITHUB.COM/ABYRVALG379

FLOMASTER is a launcher for 3D graphics applications: one button starts Blender, Maya, Houdini, Nuke, DaVinci Resolve, Unreal Engine or Substance Painter with a predefined OCIO color config. The launcher finds installed applications automatically, keeps launch presets and profiles, opens project files, runs from the command line and logs every launch. One color config - across all applications, with no manual environment setup.

github.com/abyrvalg379/FLOMASTER

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1. ABOUT FLOMASTER

Key features:

- auto-scan of installed applications from the Windows registry, Epic Games manifests and file search — Blender, K-Cycles, Maya, Houdini, Nuke and NukeX, DaVinci Resolve, Unreal Engine, Substance Painter;
- launch presets: your own name, exe and launch arguments;
- launch profiles: named app + OCIO config + arguments bundles, one-click project switching;
- fullscreen overlay dashboard by Ctrl+Alt+F: color config, applications, projects, profiles, roles and recent files — over everything;
- project routing: .spp opens in Substance Painter, .blend in Blender, .hip in Houdini;
- OCIO roles: per-preset role overrides without touching the config;
- a command line for batch files and farms;
- settings transfer between machines via a file;
- 7 color themes including the window title bar, and a global Ctrl+Alt+F hotkey;
- system tray with quick launch of presets and profiles;
- launch log and auto-update from GitHub.

2. INSTALLATION AND UPDATES

- Download the latest release: github.com/abyrvalg379/FLOMASTER → Releases → Latest.
- Extract the archive to a folder of your choice (e.g. C:\Program Files\FLOMASTER).
- Run FLOMASTER.exe. The build is self-contained: .NET 8 is bundled, nothing else to install.
- The window opens in the top-right corner of the screen. User data (settings and the log) is created in %APPDATA%\FLOMASTER\.
- Auto-update: on start the launcher compares its version against the latest release on GitHub. If a new one is out, it is downloaded in the background with no action on your side; a Restart and install button appears in Settings.

2.1 Auto-update

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
Check at startup	~3 seconds after launch the version is compared against the latest GitHub release
Update banner	an accent banner in the header of both windows appears as soon as an update is found: live progress with percent and a What's new button
Release notes	What's new reveals the update description: on wide screens a dedicated panel in the free space on the left (full-height text, progress inside), on narrow ones an in-banner expansion; Full notes on GitHub opens the release page
Background download	the update downloads in full (exe + the ocio folder) into a temp folder
Restart and install	button in Settings: one UAC prompt — the launcher closes, replaces its exe and restarts on the new version
Disable	the Check for updates on start checkbox in Settings

The whole package is updated: the exe and the ocio folder. Settings, profiles and the log in %APPDATA% stay exactly as they were. Nothing is installed until you press the button — the download is a background operation with no side effects.

2.2 Manual update

Close the launcher (including the tray), replace the files, start it again. Settings and the log live apart from the program and survive updates.

3. QUICK START

- Start FLOMASTER — the auto-scan finds installed applications.
- Pick an application in the APPLICATION list and click Launch — it starts with the OCIO config.
- Check the color spaces in the application (in Blender — the Color Management tab in scene properties).
- Expand the Projects panel, add a project folder with the "+" button and open a file with a click — it starts in the matching application.
- Press Save current as profile in the Profiles panel — the current app + config + arguments bundle is saved under a name.
- Ctrl+Alt+F opens the fullscreen dashboard over everything: color config, applications, projects, profiles and roles on one screen.

4. PRESETS AND AUTO-SCAN

4.1 Auto-scan

On start the launcher looks for installed applications: first in the Windows registry and Epic Games Launcher manifests, then by file search in standard locations. Something installed in a non-standard folder (portable builds, custom versions)? Add the folder in Settings → Scan paths and the card appears on the next scan.

4.2 Custom presets

A preset is a pair of "name + path to exe". Two ways to create one:

- drag the application exe right into the launcher window - you will be asked for a name;
- create a preset manually and point it to the exe.

Each preset carries its own launch arguments (the Quick commands panel) - that is how you keep several versions of one application or special launch keys.

5. LAUNCH PROFILES

A profile is a named snapshot of a launch state: application + OCIO config + arguments. It is the unit of task switching: "project A" and "project B" differ by one click instead of re-tuning three fields.

- set the application, OCIO config and arguments, expand the Profiles panel and press Save current as profile;
- clicking a profile restores the whole bundle (profiles reference the preset and config by name — edits are picked up);
- the cross deletes a profile (with confirmation);
- the tray menu has a PROFILES section — launch a profile straight from the tray, no window needed.

A typical set: one profile per project (different OCIO configs), one per application version, one for background rendering (bake arguments). Profiles travel between machines with your settings — see "Moving to another machine".

6. PROJECTS PANEL

The Projects panel is a project file browser inside the launcher: instead of digging through the file manager you open the needed file with one click.

- add the folder where your projects live with the "+" button (a root); "−" removes the selected root;
- the list shows every project file under the root recursively, with relative paths;
- a click opens the file in the matching application: .spp — in Substance Painter, .blend — in Blender, .hip — in Houdini (the application is picked by extension, even if another one is selected in the list);
- the A-Z / Date / Apps chips in the section header sort the list; clicking the active Apps chip again rotates the app groups — all .spp files (or any other family) jump to the top in one click, groups with no files do not waste clicks;
- Recent — the same rule: recent files reopen in their applications.

7. THE FULLSCREEN DASHBOARD

Ctrl+Alt+F opens the launcher over every window: color config, applications, projects, profiles, roles, recent files and settings — on one screen. Ctrl+Alt+F again or Esc closes the dashboard. The dashboard carries the full launcher functionality: configs, applications, profiles, project folders and settings are managed right here.

- COLOR CONFIG: click a chip to switch the config; + and − in the section header add and remove configs;
- the NO OCIO chip (first in the list) launches applications in their default color management, without OCIO; pin it in a profile or make it the default config;
- APPLICATIONS: tiles with real exe icons, click = launch; right-click a tile to launch with a command preset (clean start, background render, etc.) or to save a profile; + and rescan in the section header;
- PROJECTS: root chips and project files, a click opens the file in the matching application; + adds a folder, right-click a root chip removes it;
- RUNNING: chips of live DCC instances next to the search; click brings the app forward, right-click offers focus and restart;
- PROFILES: a click applies the profile and launches the application; "Save current as profile" in the section header;
- OCIO ROLES: clicking a role slides in a right-hand drawer with a family-grouped colorspace tree and search, Reset returns the config values;
- RECENT FILES: recent files, a click reopens them; Clear empties the list;
- SETTINGS (footer): THEME (theme, default config), BEHAVIOUR (hotkey, startup and always-on-top modes), MAINTENANCE (rescan, scan paths, SYNC, sync folder, shortcuts, log);
- the header switcher (the icon left of "minimize") swaps the fullscreen dashboard and the small window — the same item lives in the tray; Ctrl+Alt+F always toggles what you see;

The search box filters everything on the fly: Enter launches the first match, the Up/Down arrows walk the visible tiles. The Log chip pulls up a log drawer at the bottom (last 200 entries, text is copyable). The drawers - log, roles and the update panel - slide in smoothly; the Launcher animation toggle restores instant appearance.

The dashboard opens on the monitor where it was last closed (remembered in the settings) and can be dragged between monitors by its header — sizes adapt to each monitor. If you do not need it above other windows — untick Dashboard on top. The Start with dashboard toggle makes the launcher open with the fullscreen dashboard.

8. PROJECT FILES

Drag a project file onto the launcher window — the file opens in the matching application with the OCIO config applied: .spp — in Substance Painter, .blend — in Blender, .hip — in Houdini (the application is picked by extension, even if another one is selected in the list). Supported: .blend, .spp, .ma, .mb, .hip, .hipl, .hipnc, .nk. Recently opened files are available in the Recent list — a click reopens them in their applications.

9. OCIO ROLES

The Roles panel shows what the key color roles of the selected config resolve to (scene_linear, data, default_byte and others) — and lets you override them per preset.

- clicking a role row slides in a right-hand drawer: colorspaces as a family-grouped tree, like the Color Space menu in Blender, with search; a query switches the list to flat matches;
- overrides are stored in the launcher config, and a derived config is built at launch — the original .ocio file is never modified;
- Reset returns all roles of the preset to the config values;
- under the config selector — a validation line: missing critical roles and broken references are highlighted in advance.

10. HOW OCIO SUPPORT WORKS

Most applications read the config path from the OCIO environment variable - the launcher sets it on launch. Unreal Engine ignores the variable: it receives the path as a -ocio="path" argument - the launcher does that for you.

APPLICATION	METHOD
Blender, Maya, Houdini, Nuke, DaVinci Resolve, Substance Painter	OCIO environment variable
Unreal Engine	-ocio= argument

Nuke: the variable provides and locks the config - Nuke shows "OCIO environment variable is set" and disables switching configs from inside. The project color-management mode lives in the script itself: in a new .nk set Project Settings → Color → color management to OCIO once. Since Nuke 16, Nuke, NukeX and Studio ship as one binary - the launcher shows both tiles; NukeX runs via the --nukex flag and carries its native icon.

The bundled ACES 1.2 config (the ocio/ folder next to the exe) defines lowercase aliases acescg and raw: interchange ACES names identical across applications and configs. Scripts and presets that set a colorspace by the acescg or raw string survive config changes - long names like "ACES - ACEScg" are unique to one config. The transforms behind an alias and its long name are identical.

Default roles in the bundled config are tuned for a typical texture cycle: 8-bit images open as raw, float images (EXR) - as acescg.

11. THEMES AND THE WINDOW CHROME

Seven color schemes - one per application in the pipeline. Switch the theme in Settings; the entire interface follows: buttons, checkboxes, the scrollbar, dropdown menus, the window title strip and the Launch button hover state.

THEME	ACCENT	BASE
Blender	orange	dark graphite
Maya	cyan	blue-gray
Houdini	red-orange	dark (sampled from the real UI)
Nuke	light gray	graphite, monochrome
DaVinci	pink-red	purple-navy
Unreal	blue	cool graphite
Substance	green	black

The title strip is drawn by the launcher itself, in the theme colors: the application name on the left, minimize and close buttons on the right. Drag the window by the strip.

12. SETTINGS

The small window collects settings in the Settings panel; the dashboard footer groups them into three blocks: THEME (theme and the default config), BEHAVIOUR (hotkey, startup and always-on-top modes), MAINTENANCE (rescan, scan paths, SYNC, shortcuts, log).

SETTING	WHAT IT DOES
Check for updates on start	auto-update check at launch
Theme	interface color theme
Start with Windows	auto-start with Windows
Start with dashboard	open with the fullscreen dashboard at startup
Always on top	the small launcher window above all others
Dashboard on top	fullscreen dashboard above all windows
Global hotkey (Ctrl+Alt+F)	global hotkey: show/hide the dashboard
Hotkey opens dashboard	what the hotkey opens: the dashboard or the small window
Launcher animation	enable/disable panel animation
Default OCIO	default config for tray launches
Scan paths	extra folders for the auto-scan
SYNC	export/import settings to move them to another machine
Shortcuts	Start Menu and desktop shortcuts

13. TRAY AND LOG

Closing the window minimizes the launcher to the system tray - it keeps running. The tray menu offers quick launch of presets, a PROFILES section (one-click profile launches) and the window itself. Quit — in the tray menu.

In the dashboard the Log chip pulls up a log drawer (last 200 entries, copyable text). In the small window the Log button opens the log window beside the launcher. Every launch is logged: timestamp, user, application,

OCIO config, exit code. A "Set OCIO=..." line marks that the config was actually passed. The log file lives at %APPDATA%\FLOMASTER\flomaster.log.

14. COMMAND LINE

The launcher runs without a window - for batch files, farms and scripts:

FLOMASTER.exe --list-profiles

FLOMASTER.exe --launch "Profile"

FLOMASTER.exe --launch "Profile" --project "D:\projects\A\shot_042.blend"

A profile resolves to application + OCIO config + arguments - the same environment as a manual launch. --project appends the file to the profile arguments (or substitutes the {file} placeholder if the profile has one).

EXIT CODE	MEANING
0	launched successfully
1	launch or usage error
2	profile, preset or project file not found

Output goes to the console the exe was started from. Environment variables and OCIO are passed exactly like a window launch.

15. MOVING TO ANOTHER MACHINE

Manual transfer: Settings → SYNC → Export settings saves profiles, project roots, theme and options into a flomaster_setup_date.flomaster file. On another machine: install the launcher, press Import settings and pick the file.

The sync folder transfers settings hands-free. In MAINTENANCE press Sync folder and pick any folder your Dropbox/OneDrive/NAS keeps in sync across machines. Your own FLOMASTER_<pc-name>.flomaster file is written there automatically whenever settings change; other machines' files are offered as an Import chip and apply only on your click. Profiles, project roots, theme and behaviour flags travel; exe and OCIO paths stay machine-local.

- profiles are imported by name: new ones are added, existing ones updated;
- project roots merge without duplicates;
- exe paths stay machine-local: presets match by name, so after importing check that applications are found (Rescan);

The auto-scan on a fresh machine picks up installed applications from the registry and Epic manifests — as a rule, presets assemble themselves.

16. FILES AND FOLDERS

PATH	CONTENTS
installation folder	FLOMASTER.exe, flomaster.ico, ocio/ (ACES 1.2 config + luts/), LICENSE.txt
%APPDATA%\FLOMASTER	launcher_config.json (settings), flomaster.log (log), variants/ (per-role config variants)

The program and user data are deliberately separated: reinstalling and updating never touch settings, presets or the log.

17. WORKFLOWS

One color from the start of the day

Launcher window → Launch on the application you need. Everything you start that day runs on the same config - files travel between applications without color surprises.

Switching between projects

Set up one profile per project and switch them in the Profiles panel with a single click. From the tray a profile launches right away, without the launcher window. The fullscreen dashboard (Ctrl+Alt+F) shows the config, applications and project files on one screen.

Open a project file without leaving the task

Projects panel → root → click the file. Name search finds files deep inside folders. The file opens in the right application — extension routing works in the dashboard too.

Textures: what opens and where

Float images (EXR) open as acescg - the color cycle is correct right away. 8-bit images open as raw: the right default for data maps (normals, masks, roughness) with no manual clicks. Assign a colorspace manually to a color 8-bit map if it opened as raw.

Background render from a batch file

Save a profile with bake arguments and run: FLOMASTER.exe --launch "Render" --project "scene.blend". Exit code 0 — the process is on its way.

Several versions of one application

Create one preset per version (drag the exe + name) and start the one you need with a click; the version arguments live in the preset Quick commands.

18. TROUBLESHOOTING

SYMPTOM	CAUSE	WHAT TO DO
Application missing after installation	non-standard install folder	add the folder in Settings → Scan paths or create a preset by dragging the exe
Ctrl+Alt+F does nothing	the combination is taken by another application	check for a warn line in the log; free the combination or toggle the Global hotkey checkbox off and on
The dashboard opened on the wrong monitor	monitor memory is updated when the dashboard closes	drag the dashboard by its header to the monitor you need — it will be remembered
Profile does not start from the command line, exit code 2	profile/preset/file not found	check the profile name with --list-profiles; presets match by name

SYMPTOM	CAUSE	WHAT TO DO
Project file is not visible in the Projects panel	only native DCC formats are listed (.blend, .spp, .ma, .mb, .hip, .hipl, .hipnc, .nk)	use name search or drag the file into the window directly
Unreal started with the wrong color	Unreal does not read the OCIO variable	keep the -ocio= argument in the preset arguments - that is how the launcher passes the config
Error «enum "Non-Color" not found» on import	the bundled config has no colorspace named Non-Color (the raw alias exists)	import outside this OCIO config, or add a colorspace/alias with that name to the config
A color 8-bit map opened as raw	the default_byte role in the config is raw (the default for data maps)	assign a colorspace manually to that map: sRGB space for 8-bit color, acescg for float
Log window is nowhere to be seen	it opens beside the launcher, at the same height	look to the left/right of the launcher window
Settings and log "disappeared" after reinstall	they do not live in the program folder	look in %APPDATA%\FLOMASTER\ - updates never touch them